



I CAN'T FIGURE OUT IF YOU'RE A DETECTIVE OR A PERVERT

BLUE VELVET / 1986

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Thriller, mystery

DIRECTOR

David Lynch

WRITER

David Lynch

STARS

Kyle MacLachlan, Isabella Rossellini, Dennis Hopper, Laura Dern

BEFORE

1957 Alfred Hitchcock's *Rear Window* explores the nature of voyeurism as a wheelchair-bound photographer spies on his neighbors.

1977 Lynch's debut feature *Eraserhead* is a surreal horror shot in black and white.

AFTER

1980 *The Elephant Man* is Lynch's sensitive real-life drama about a disfigured man.

2001 *Mulholland Dr.* is Lynch's neo-noir LA mystery about an aspiring actress.



Rich, haunting and subversive, *Blue Velvet* is the story of a college student drawn into the seamy underside of his hometown after he finds a severed human ear in a field.

Since his extraordinary 1977 debut with *Eraserhead*, David Lynch has become a genre unto himself, a master of combining the shocking, the comic, and the surreal in what feel like visions straight from the subconscious—cinematic dreams (or nightmares). If anything, *Blue Velvet* is one of his more straightforward movies, without the complex structure of

Jeffrey (Kyle MacLachlan) finds himself trapped in Dorothy's closet when Frank arrives. He must look on helpless at what unfolds.

his later masterpiece, *Mulholland Dr.* Instead it follows the structure of an old-fashioned film noir, as the curious but strait-laced young student Jeffrey (Kyle MacLachlan) falls for the wholesome Sandy (Laura Dern), but is also attracted to the nightclub singer Dorothy (Isabella Rossellini), who is trapped in an abusive relationship with the psychopathic villain Frank (Dennis Hopper). This dynamic is clearly